

Chapter 80 - Chess Game

Feng Yue was lost in thought because of Yan Lin's words, while Yan Lin continued chattering on about various things.

After a while, the smell of burning from the pot grew stronger and stronger. Only then did Yan Lin stop washing dishes and look toward Feng Yue.

She saw Feng Yue standing there in a daze, the long chopsticks in her hands having not turned the chicken wings in the pot for quite some time.

Yan Lin walked over and gently patted Feng Yue's shoulder. "Ah Yue?"

Feng Yue, who had been lost in thought, was startled. The chopsticks in her hands became unsteady and slipped from her grasp into the pot.

Feng Yue almost instinctively tried to fish out the chopsticks, but Yan Lin's face changed and she quickly reached out to stop her.

The chopsticks, knocked about by both of them, flipped up from the pot due to the force and fell to the ground. A few drops of hot oil carried by the chopstick tips splattered mostly onto Yan Lin's sleeve, but a small portion still landed on the back of her hand.

The boiling hot oil immediately scalded red marks on her hand, and Yan Lin couldn't help but suck in a sharp breath.

The small accident happened extremely quickly. Before Feng Yue could even react, Yan Lin immediately reached out to turn off the fire under the oil pot, then pulled Feng Yue back a distance.

Feng Yue looked at Yan Lin's scalded red hand, her brows furrowing tightly. She then silently pulled Yan Lin to the sink and turned on the faucet to rinse the wound.

The ice-cold, bone-chilling water washed over the burn that felt like fire, the contrast making Yan Lin's wrist, which Feng Yue was holding, tremble uncontrollably.

Feng Yue closed her eyes in some annoyance. How could she have spaced out in front of a boiling oil pot!

"Sorry..."

"Ah Yue, are you alright?"

Both spoke at the same time.

Yan Lin was stunned for a moment, then smiled slightly and reached up to tuck a strand of hair behind her ear. "No need to apologize. If I hadn't suddenly patted you, you wouldn't have been startled."

Feng Yue didn't answer her. No matter how much she disliked Yan Lin, she had no reason to blame her for this incident.

Frying things in hot oil was inherently dangerous, and she had been distracted thinking about other things.

Seeing that the wound had been rinsed enough, Feng Yue said, "Go sit in the living room for a while. I'll get the first aid kit - there's burn ointment in it."

"Mm."

Yan Lin nodded and obediently returned to sit in the living room.

At this time, Jiang Shu came in to get ingredients. Seeing Yan Lin sitting in the living room holding her hand, she asked, "Ah Lin, what happened? Are you injured?"

"Mm, I accidentally got burned just now."

"Oh my, did you rinse it with cold water?" Jiang Shu was somewhat worried and wanted to check how serious it was. "Where's Nuannuan¹? Is she alright? If she's fine, have her find some burn ointment for you. We should have some at home."

"Ah Yue is fine. She's already gone to get the first aid kit."

Jiang Shu nodded. Her mouth moved as if she wanted to say something more, but she suddenly stopped and only instructed Yan Lin to apply the medicine properly before hurrying out to the yard with the ingredients.

When Jiang Shu went out carrying the plate, she happened to run into Feng Hehai walking into the house.

Jiang Shu quickly grabbed him and pulled him toward the yard.

Feng Hehai was pulled away from the house by his wife, looking completely bewildered. "Hey, hey, hey, what's this about? I need to go in and get a cup!"

"Come on, come on, it's not the right time yet!"

"Huh?"

Just like that, Jiang Shu dragged away the confused Feng Hehai without giving him any explanation.

When Feng Yue came out with the first aid kit, only the two of them were left in the living room.

Yan Lin's burn wasn't large, but thinking of her bleeding condition that was nearly impossible to stop, Feng Yue's brow furrowed.

So what would be a relatively minor wound on an ordinary person couldn't be taken lightly when it came to Yan Lin.

Feng Yue used a cotton swab to carefully clean the water droplets from the back of her hand, then dipped it in ointment to apply it.

Sunlight and tranquility flowed between the two of them. This was probably the first time in so long that they had sat together so peacefully with skin contact.

Feng Yue's fingers from one hand supported Yan Lin's palm, while her other hand held a cotton swab to apply ointment to the back of her hand.

Yan Lin felt the warm, soft, and delicate sensation coming from her palm, her heart tingling as her fingers couldn't help but curl slightly.

Sensing Yan Lin's movement, Feng Yue only paused briefly before continuing to apply the ointment, though her speed did increase noticeably.

"Done. Don't get it wet." Feng Yue threw the used cotton swab into the trash can and quickly packed up the first aid kit.

"You can go out now. The kitchen doesn't need your help anymore, and your hand can't get wet, so there's no point staying here." Speaking thus, Feng Yue picked up the first aid kit and stood up. However, as she stood, she noticed that Yan Lin's clothes had been stained with oil splatters over a large area.

Yan Lin's jacket was no longer wearable.

Feng Yue felt somewhat troubled, but she would take responsibility for her own mistakes. "Wait for me a moment."

She then turned and headed upstairs to the bedroom.

When Feng Yue came back downstairs, Yan Lin saw a beige jacket draped over her arm.

"Put this jacket on. It's my mom's jacket. I'll take care of the stains on your clothes."

Yan Lin looked down and was about to shake her head and refuse when she heard Feng Yue's voice rise slightly: "Put it on."

Yan Lin blinked, then began unbuttoning her jacket.

Yan Lin was half a head taller than Feng Yue, and Feng Yue was half a head taller than Jiang Shu. By this calculation, Jiang Shu's jacket didn't fit Yan Lin very well.

Feng Yue looked at Yan Lin's sleeves that were obviously too short and felt somewhat embarrassed. She hadn't expected the sleeves to be this short.

"It looks good." Yan Lin probably noticed her awkwardness and gently comforted her.

Feng Yue made a muffled sound of agreement. "Just make do with it for now. You can change back to your own jacket this afternoon."

She then took Yan Lin's jacket to the laundry room in the back.

Actually, it wasn't that Feng Yue couldn't find a jacket that would fit Yan Lin properly. After all, they weren't that different in height, and winter jackets were generally cut loose anyway, so her jacket would have fit Yan Lin too.

But Feng Yue just didn't want to lend her own jacket to the other person.

That would seem to imply they were the kind of people who could share each other's clothes.

In reality, they were a divorced couple who had only separated a few months ago.

After changing clothes, Yan Lin no longer had any reason to stay inside, so she could only reluctantly return to the yard, looking back every few steps.

With many people in the yard, it was naturally quite noisy. The loudest were naturally Grandfather and Jiang Ming.

The grandfather and granddaughter were sitting at a small table playing chess, except they were playing Western chess².

Jiang Ming probably couldn't beat Grandfather, but she was very competitive, so she could only pull Jiang Zhao aside to ask about each move.

Jiang Zhao wasn't particularly good at chess either. Facing the composed Grandfather, the siblings were thoroughly defeated.

When Yan Lin came out, the three-person chess game had just ended.

Grandfather sat facing Yan Lin's direction. When he saw her, he snorted through his nose.

The siblings turned around and noticed something different.

How did going in to wash some vegetables result in changing jackets?

Jiang Ming stood up ready to question her, but Jiang Zhao quickly pulled her back and said, "Miss Yan, would you like to play a game with Grandfather? We just finished."

Hearing this, Yan Lin turned her gaze toward the grandfather sitting there.

Although Grandfather's face still showed his unwillingness to talk much with Yan Lin, he was indeed feeling somewhat eager to play.

"Keep that old fellow company for a while. He hasn't had a good game of chess in ages," said the grandmother sitting not far away, looking at Yan Lin with kind eyes.

Only after hearing her words did Yan Lin dare to sit across from Grandfather.

"Grandfather, shall we play Western chess?" Yan Lin inquired.

Grandfather's face stiffened. Before he could speak, the grandmother said from the side, "Xiao Ming³, go to your father's study and get the Go set from the bookcase..."

Hearing this, Grandfather's expression softened slightly, though he still pretended to glare disapprovingly at Feng Yue's grandmother.

That old woman was just being meddlesome!

Although he had previously been no match for this Yan girl at Western chess, who could guarantee he wouldn't win today?

Following Grandmother's orders, Jiang Ming quickly went upstairs to the study and found a Go set.

The Jiang Zhao and Jiang Ming siblings had lived abroad for a long time. Although their Chinese was quite good, they truly knew nothing about Go.

After setting up the board, Yan Lin took black and Grandfather took white, beginning their chess game that had been interrupted for almost a year.

Grandfather truly lived up to his reputation. His chess style was steady and watertight. Even when small flaws appeared, he could turn danger into safety later on.

But Yan Lin, who was usually unhurried and methodical, appeared particularly aggressive in this game. Not only did she press forward step by step, but she also set countless obvious traps for Grandfather in the subsequent moves.

From the moment Grandfather noticed Yan Lin's change, his brow had been slightly furrowed.

He could sense this girl's transformation and could avoid her traps one by one, but he always felt something wasn't quite right.

This unsettling feeling surrounded him continuously, and he remained cautious throughout.

But it wasn't until Yan Lin's black stone fell in the heart of Grandfather's formation that this fog-shrouded chess game gradually became clear before his eyes.

Grandfather looked at the game's progression, his eyes blazing. "Brilliant!"

He placed two white stones on the board, then began carefully studying this game.

Seeing this, Yan Lin also returned the black stone in her hand to the bowl.

Jiang Ming saw that the two had stopped playing and curiously approached Jiang Zhao. "Why did they stop? Who lost?"

Although Jiang Zhao couldn't play Go, he understood the basic rules. "Grandfather conceded by placing stones⁴. Putting two stones on the board means surrender."

Jiang Ming was astonished. She never would have expected that Grandfather would be the one to lose.

Here, Grandfather had finally seen through the entire game clearly. He looked at Yan Lin: "You were laying this trap from the very beginning, weren't you? The aggressive playing style was also an act to fool me."

Yan Lin nodded like an obedient student. "Mm, Grandfather is very strong. I could only use unconventional tactics."

"Alright, alright. A loss is a loss. I'm not someone who can't accept defeat. No need to flatter me." Grandfather waved his hand dismissively, then lowered his head to study the game again.

During this, Grandfather secretly glanced at her, then sighed inwardly.

He had always believed that chess style revealed character. Yan Lin's chess style had been a model of patient, step-by-step play from early on, so when they used to play chess, they would often spend entire afternoons at it.

He had also always felt that this child's relationship with his dear granddaughter would be like her chess style - plain but not lacking in charm.

Yet the two children had divorced after just over a year of marriage.

He didn't know what had happened between the two children, but judging from today's game, this girl Yan Lin was indeed different from before.

She would actively fight for what she wanted, would show more desire, and was more human-like.

Footnotes:

¹ Nuannuan (囡囡): A term of endearment meaning "little girl" or "baby girl," used by Jiang Shu for Feng Yue.

² Western chess (西洋棋): This refers to international chess (the standard chess game), as opposed to Chinese chess (xiangqi) or Go (weiqi).

³ Xiao Ming (小茗): "Little Ming" - a diminutive, affectionate way to address Jiang Ming.

⁴ Placing stones (投子): In Go, placing two stones on the board is a formal way to resign/concede the game.